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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

Author(S): Evans-Pritchard, E. E. (Edward Evan)**Document Type:** Book**Original Page:** 206**Culture (OWC):** [Azande \(F007\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Central Africa**Field Date:** 1926-1930**Coverage Date:** Late 1800s-1930**Place Coverage:** Zande District, Sudan**Section Title(S):** III

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I have often observed three or four witch-doctors, and sometimes as many as seven or eight, gather in the homestead of an experienced colleague, who knows all the medicinal herbs and trees from which a magic stew is made, and there partake of a communal meal. This senior witch-doctor, who is also generally the owner of the homestead at which the ceremony takes place, has already dug up in the bush a number of roots, and scraped and washed them preparatory to cooking. He places them with water in a pot and he and his colleagues gather round the fire to watch them boil. They chat and joke among themselves about a variety of secular subjects, though the affairs of their profession are also sometimes discussed. They display no outward manifestations of awe and reverence. After the water has boiled for some time and become coloured from the juices of the plants, the witch-doctor who has gathered them and is cooking them, and whom I shall refer to as their owner, takes the pot off the fire and pours out the liquid into a second pot, which he places on the fire for further boiling. The roots from which the juices have been extracted are removed to a nearby hut, where they are stored for another occasion.

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At this point the witch-doctors commence to rivet their attention upon the business in hand, drop their secular conversation, and develop a noticeable degree of concentration on the medicinal juices now boiling on the fire. This is the first sign in their behaviour that they are dealing with magical forces. Spells from this point accompany various phases of the cooking and continue seriatim till the end of the ceremony. When the owner is pouring out his medicinal juices into a second pot for their further boiling he generally

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addresses them in a few words, asking for the welfare of witch-doctors as a whole and for the success of their professional interests. He  207 then divides up a ball of paste, made from oil-bearing seeds ground down with a magic root, into several small round balls, one for each witch-doctor present. The owner places these along the periphery of the pot and first he and then each witch-doctor in order of seniority flicks his ball into the pot. The owner now takes a little wooden stirrer and slowly stirs the oil in the juices, addressing the medicines as he does so, partly on his own behalf and partly on behalf of the novice whom he is initiating:

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

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